



[Home](#) > [News](#) > [Southwest Airlines Privacy Policy Tracking Pricing Concerns](#)

Southwest Airlines Updated Its Privacy Policy And Passengers Are Worried About Tracking and Higher Prices

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Southwest Airlines has quietly updated its privacy policy, and while the airline sent out an email to customers on Monday, March 30, 2026 notifying them of the change, it gave almost no detail about what actually changed. That silence has triggered widespread concern among passengers, with many now worried that Southwest is building the tools for heavier data tracking, biometric monitoring, and personalized pricing commonly known as dynamic pricing.



The email Southwest sent on March 30 was vague and told customers very little. However, a closer look at the full privacy policy reveals that the most significant changes were actually made back in January 2026 not on March 30. The March email simply drew attention to a policy that had already been quietly expanded months earlier without much public notice.

According to the updated policy, Southwest now reserves the right to collect and use a significantly broader range of customer data. This includes session replay technology, mouse movements and screen captures, clickstream data showing how users navigate the website, detailed in-flight Wi-Fi usage information, including websites visited, location-identifying technologies, audio and video capture at airports, and data collected through its Touchless ID biometric login system used in its mobile app.

The policy also states that Southwest can combine all of this automatically collected data with personal information, build detailed usage profiles on individual customers, retarget customers across other websites, share data with partners, and use the information for automation and artificial intelligence, including training AI systems.

Why Passengers Are Worried

The concern among Southwest customers, which has been widely discussed on Reddit and across travel communities, centers on one key fear that this data will be used to charge different customers different prices based on their personal spending habits and behaviour. This practice is known as surveillance pricing or dynamic pricing, and it is already used in various forms across the technology and retail industries.

The specific fears include Southwest using past purchase behavior to hide lower fares from customers who regularly buy more expensive options, using historical seating data to charge higher prices for exit rows or premium seats to customers who have paid for them before, and adjusting the value of Rapid Rewards points based on individual loyalty levels and spending habits. It is worth noting that as of early 2026, Rapid Rewards points are no longer fixed in value and have moved to a fully dynamic pricing model meaning the number of points needed for a flight can change.

Southwest has not confirmed that it is currently doing any of these things. However, the language in its privacy policy is broad enough to allow all of them.

What Southwest Has Not Said

The airline has not made any public statement clarifying exactly what the privacy policy changes mean in practice for everyday customers. It has not confirmed or denied whether it is using customer profiles to adjust fares or ancillary pricing on an individual basis. The lack of communication is itself a significant part of the problem. By sending a vague email without explaining what changed, Southwest left customers to fill in the gaps themselves, which has understandably led to concern and speculation.

It is also important to note that some of the tracking practices now permitted under the policy such as biometric data collected through Touchless ID are tied to specific features like airport check-in and mobile app login, rather than being applied broadly to



A Bigger Trend in the Airline Industry



Rising Airline Data Tre

Southwest is not alone in expanding its data-driven approach. Other major carriers are increasingly investing in data analytics to understand customer behavior, personalize services, and move away from Southwest's traditional low-cost model. This trend is known for its impact on the data-driven approach across US aviation.

For travelers who have long valued the Southwest approach, these changes represent a shift in its policy and its customers. Whether or not the new policy now gives it the legal room to operate, it's a significant change.

Please Note: If you are a Southwest traveler, it is worth being aware of these changes and how they might affect your travel plans.

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He is Director of Operations at Moresand Limited, running Crystaltravel.co.uk (38 years in business, 38,000+ Trustpilot reviews) and Mundotrip.com. 20+ years in travel, from retail and B2B distribution to operations. His team processes thousands of bookings annually across flights, hotels, car rentals, cruises, and packages. Information on this site comes from actual booking data and supplier records.



